

PROFESSOR INGRID RIEDLE'S POLITICAL SCIENCE 201



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Professor Ingrid Riedle's Political Science 201

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Glossary

Detailed Licensing

Detailed Licensing

Licensing

A detailed breakdown of this resource's licensing can be found in [Back Matter/Detailed Licensing](#).

Freedom for whom? Rights over order, or order over rights? How do Marxists perceive of minority rights, for example, compared to fascists? What kind of society do they want to create, and how does it differ from the goals of a socialist, conservative, or a libertarian?

These are only some of the fundamental questions that political ideologies seek to answer, each with their own coherent world view.

By engaging with the readings and the classroom activity, and by analyzing your own political ideology in the homework assignment, you will deepen your understanding of ideologies in general and their effect on our society's DEI efforts in particular.

Student Learning Outcomes

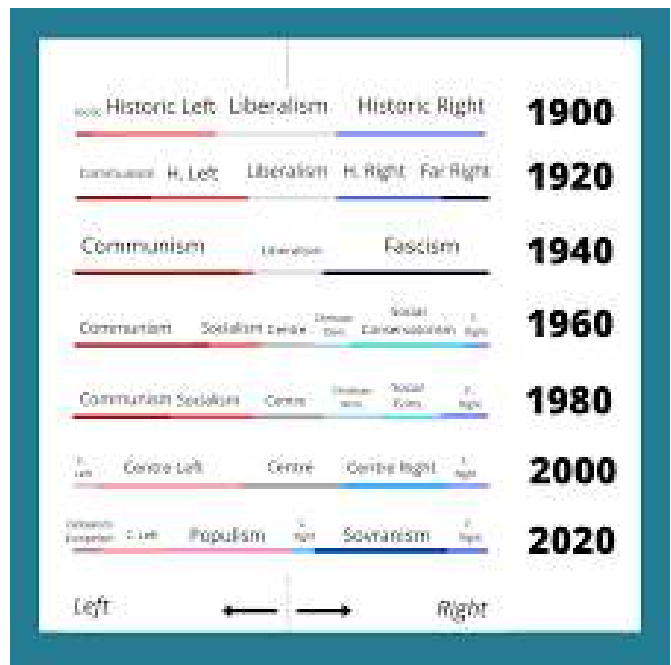
1. Explain the basics of major political ideologies (liberalism, conservatism, socialism, etc.) in your own words.
2. Compare different ideologies—how do they view freedom, equality, and power?
3. Connect ideologies to real-world issues, especially debates about fairness, discrimination, and inclusion.
4. Understand how politicians and laws are influenced by these ideologies.
5. Reflect on your own views—which ideologies do you agree or disagree with, and why?
6. Discuss these ideas respectfully, even when people disagree.

*Heywood, A. (2021). *Political ideologies: An introduction* (7th ed.). Red Globe Press.

[1.1: Political Ideologies - Readings and Media](#)

[1.2: Political Ideologies - Classroom Activity](#)

[1.3: Political Ideologies - Homework](#)



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1.2: Political Ideologies - Classroom Activity

Debate: Do We Need Universal Healthcare in Our Country?

1. Form 7 **groups** (one for each ideology considered here).
2. Choose ONE **ideology** for your group: liberalism, socialism, Marxism, anarchism, conservatism, libertarianism, or fascism.
3. Each group reviews the **main tenets** and key ideas of their chosen ideology.
4. Groups develop 5 **arguments** for and/or against the debate question, depending on their assigned ideology, making sure that their arguments are true to their ideological principles:

Should the government provide universal healthcare for all?

5. Groups prepare a **brief statement** introducing and outlining their stance.
6. Each group **presents** their arguments to each other.
7. Engage in **rebuttals**.
8. **Class Reflection**
 - A. How did your assigned ideology shape your perspective on the issue?
 - B. Which ideological arguments did you find most convincing?
 - C. Which ideology would ultimately create a fairer, just, and inclusive society?
 - D. Did any perspective challenge your personal beliefs?



Evaluation Rubric

Criteria	Exemplary (4 pts)	Proficient (3 pts)	Developing (2 pts)	Beginning (1 pt)	Score
1. Ideological Accuracy (Step 3)	Arguments perfectly reflect core tenets of assigned ideology; no contradictions.	Arguments mostly align with ideology; minor inconsistencies.	Some alignment, but several arguments stray from ideological principles.	Little or no connection to assigned ideology.	/4
2. Quality of Arguments (Step 4)	5 strong, well-researched arguments; clear logical structure; uses evidence or reasoning appropriate to the ideology.	5 arguments present; mostly logical and relevant.	Fewer than 5 arguments or weak/irrelevant points.	Arguments missing or completely off-topic.	/4
3. Opening Statement (Step 5)	Clear, compelling, and concise introduction of stance; outlines key arguments effectively.	Clear introduction but lacks some clarity or impact.	Unclear or disorganized opening.	No coherent opening statement.	/4
4. Presentation & Delivery (Step 6)	Engaging, confident, audible; maintains eye contact; uses time well (e.g., 3–5 min).	Good delivery with minor issues (e.g., pacing, eye contact).	Poor delivery, hard to follow, or too short/long.	Inaudible, unprepared, or no presentation.	/4
5. Rebuttal Skills (Step 7)	Directly addresses opposing arguments; uses ideological logic to counter; respectful and sharp.	Addresses some arguments but misses key points; generally respectful.	Weak or off-target rebuttals; defensive or aggressive tone.	No rebuttal or irrelevant responses.	/4

Criteria	Exemplary (4 pts)	Proficient (3 pts)	Developing (2 pts)	Beginning (1 pt)	Score
6. Group Collaboration	All members participate actively in prep, presentation, and rebuttals.	Most members participate.	Only 1–2 members do most work.	Group dysfunction; minimal collaboration.	/4
7. Overall Ideological Diversity	Group shows clear contrast with other ideologies; enriches debate.	Good contrast but some overlap with others.	Limited contrast; arguments resemble another ideology.	No distinct ideological voice.	/4

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1.3: Political Ideologies - Homework

Analyzing Your Own Ideology: Where Are You Located On the Ideological Spectrum?

By conducting this assignment, you may become clearer on where you stand when it comes to your own views on DEI, as well as on issues of government, policy, and democratic values more generally.

1. Take the Ideology Quiz

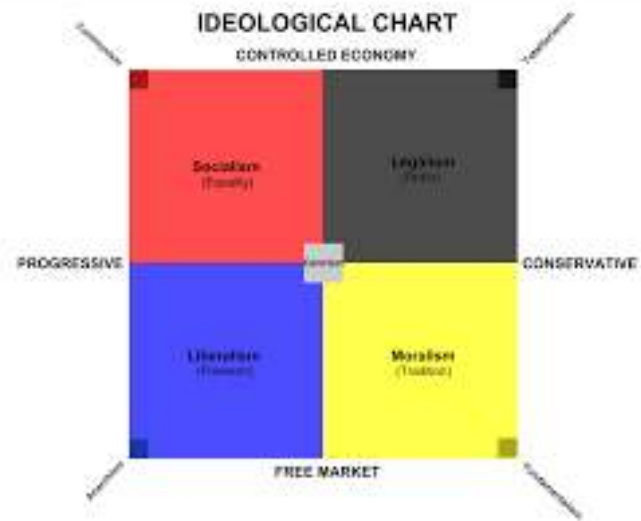
You will be asked to answer 16 policy questions. Take your time answering them but try not to overthink:

<https://www.pewresearch.org/politics...ical-typology/>

2. Write a Reflection Paper

In 400 words minimum, respond to the political ideology the Pew Research Center ascribed to you.

- Are you surprised? Why or why not?
- Reflect on our classroom activity topic of universal healthcare. What is your personal opinion on it, and does it correlate with your ideology 'diagnosis'?
- What specific policy recommendations would you champion so that our society becomes fairer, more diverse, and more inclusive?
- What about your socio-economic background -and your political socialization-correlates with your results, and what does not? Particularly think back to the *Crash Course* video and whether or not the categories fit nicely.



Evaluation Rubric

Criteria	Excellent (5 points)	Meets Expectations (4 points)	Approaches Expectations (3 points)	Needs Improvement (0-2 points)
Completeness	Clearly and completely answers the assignment prompt. Adheres to required length.	Almost completely answers the assignment prompt. Adheres to required length.	Partially addresses the assignment prompt. Adheres to required length.	Does not address the assignment prompt.
Analysis	Rich, detailed description of the case, conflict, challenge, or issue of concern.	Full description of the case, conflict, challenge, or issue of concern.	Partial description of the case, conflict, challenge, or issue of concern.	No description of the case, conflict, challenge, or issue of concern.
Evidence	Clear attempt to integrate relevant facts, relationships, and the student's self. Includes conclusions based on synthesis of the description.	Clear attempt to integrate relevant facts, relationships, and the student's self.	Slight or unclear attempt to integrate relevant facts, relationships, and the student's self.	No attempt to integrate relevant facts, relationships, and the student's self.

Criteria	Excellent (5 points)	Meets Expectations (4 points)	Approaches Expectations (3 points)	Needs Improvement (0-2 points)
Writing	Impressions plus critical reflection (i.e. exploration and critique of assumptions, values, beliefs, and/or biases; multiple perspectives; alternatives; and the consequences of actions). Includes discussion of how behavior may change based on new insights.	Impressions plus reflection (i.e. attempting to understand or question the case).	Impressions without reflection.	No impressions, reflection or introspection.

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

2: The Constitution's 14th Amendment

Engage with the 14th Amendment to the US Constitution in this learning module as it became **the foundation** for anti-discrimination, and diversity, equity, and inclusion (DEI) legislation.

Ratified right after the Civil War (1860-1865), the 14th Amendment presents three main clauses:

[Equal Protection](#)

[Citizenship](#), and

[Due Process](#).

Initially sought to establish fundamental rights and equal legal protection for former slaves, these three clauses subsequently became important touchstones for civil rights law.

Let's look at each clause in some detail:

1. The Equal Protection Clause, prohibits states from [denying to any person within its jurisdiction the equal protection of the laws](#). Aside from playing a significant role in the abolition of legal segregation, it has served as the foundation for significant Supreme Court rulings like *Brown v. Board of Education* (1954), which helped end legal discrimination and segregation in schools, by maintaining that separate can never be truly equal.

Later, the amendment became the basis for affirmative action laws, seeking to alleviate past injustices in the workplace and in education. Today, its interpretation is still hotly contested: some think that it is proactive in establishing equity (such as in race-conscious higher education admissions) while others think that it can lead to reverse discrimination. For an example of the latter, review the Supreme Court's ruling in *Students for Fair Admissions v. Harvard* (2023), and for an example of the former, see *United States v. Virginia* (1996), which combated gender discrimination.

2. The Citizenship Clause declares that [all persons born or naturalized in the United States, and subject to the jurisdiction thereof, are citizens of the United States](#). Over the two plus centuries that we have been a nation, this clause has helped grow our society and make it one of the most diverse on the planet. In recent years, though, the guarantee of birthright citizenship has been contested, especially that of children of undocumented immigrants, even if they were born in the United States. Decrying them as "anchor babies," right-wing ideologues are currently seeking to withdraw their citizenship and erase this clause's protection.

3. The Due Process Clause (also found in the 5th Amendment) is an equally important safeguard of civil liberties, yet equally contested. Prohibiting states from [depriving any person of life, liberty, or property without due process of the law](#), it requires that all people's legal rights be respected and not arbitrarily denied or altered based on prejudices. What do you think: has due process historically applied to all Americans equally? Whatever your answer, the overall trend today is negative. Increasingly, people find themselves falling through the cracks, not receiving the legal treatment Due Process is to guarantee in the Constitution.

In the readings to follow, our class activity, and your homework assignment, analyze and evaluate 14th Amendment protections more deeply, and critically assess what needs to be done to maintain them for us all.

Student Learning Outcomes

1. Explain the historical context and original intent behind the 14th Amendment.
2. Analyze the Supreme Court decisions which have interpreted the amendment.
3. Evaluate the amendment's current impact on civil rights matters.
4. Assess present-day obstacles and disputes regarding equal protection and due process.



5. Demonstrate knowledge by applying it to real-life situations through critical thinking and reflection.

[2.1: The Constitution's 14th Amendment - Readings and Media](#)

[2.2: The Constitution's 14th Amendment - Classroom Activity](#)

[2.3: The Constitution's 14th Amendment - Homework](#)

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2.1: The Constitution's 14th Amendment - Readings and Media

By engaging with the following readings and media, you develop an increasingly complex understanding of the 14th amendment to our Constitution and how it impacts our civil rights.

1. Library of Congress

Library of Congress, "14th Amendment to the U.S. Constitution: Primary Documents in American History," <https://guides.loc.gov/14th-amendment>

Find the original text of the 14th amendment here along with other resources on this issue. Carefully read through the whole document and take note especially of Section 1, the cornerstone of civil rights and constitutional law.

2. National Constitution Center

The National Constitution Center, "The Equal Protection Clause,"

<https://constitutioncenter.org/the-c...tection-clause>

Here, you have a more thorough explanation of the amendment and how it has been applied in seminal court cases over the decades, such as *Plessy v. Ferguson* (1896), or *Brown v. Board of Education* (1954). This guide also provides access to digital collections, websites, and print materials related to the amendment. You are encouraged to browse and learn more.

3. Khan Academy

(Social Movements and Equal Protection. (n.d.). In *Khan Academy*. Retrieved July 20, 2025, from <https://www.khanacademy.org/humanities/ap-us-government-and-politics/civil-liberties-and-civil-rights/social-movements-equal-protection/a/social-movements-and-equal-protection><https://www.khanacademy.org/humaniti...ual-protection>

For our visual learners, watch the story of the 14th amendment unfold in this video.

4. ACLU

Parker, Dennis, American Civil Liberties Union, 2018. <https://www.aclu.org/news/racial-justice/racial-justice>

Explore further the importance of the 14th Amendment for contemporary social issues such as same-sex marriage and transgender rights. Take note on how the logic is applied, and think about other civil rights issues it may apply to.



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2.2: The Constitution's 14th Amendment - Classroom Activity

Constitutional Discussion: The Impact of the 14th Amendment

Let's learn more about how the 14th Amendment has been used in major Supreme Court decisions and modern-day problems by dividing up the task.

1. Preparation

The class divides into four groups:

Group 1 defends the historical value and founding purpose of the 14th Amendment.

Group 2 presents arguments about the application of the 14th Amendment in racial equality cases including *Brown v. Board of Education*.

Group 3 examines how the amendment applies to gender equality and LGBTQ+ rights.

Group 4 investigates the voting rights and modern immigration policies that the amendment supports.

Each group researches its assigned topic, creates arguments for it, and prepares an opening statement.

2. Debate

-Each group presents their opening statement and key arguments.

-Other groups ask follow-up questions.

3. Class Reflection

The main points from the presentations are discussed by the class. What was learned? Which group's interpretation of the 14th Amendment was most convincing? Why?



Evaluation Rubric

Criteria	Exemplary (4 pts)	Proficient (3 pts)	Developing (2 pts)	Beginning (1 pt)	Score
1. Historical Accuracy & Research	Arguments are well-researched, historically accurate, and reference key cases, amendments, or primary sources.	Generally accurate with minor omissions or vague references.	Some factual errors or missing important historical context.	严重 factual errors or no evidence of research.	/4
2. Alignment with Assigned Topic	Group stays tightly focused on its specific topic (e.g., Group 1 on founding purpose; Group 4 on voting rights/immigration).	Mostly on topic but occasional digressions.	Often strays from assigned focus.	Ignored assigned topic entirely.	/4
3. Quality of Arguments	Arguments are logical, well-structured, and supported by specific Supreme Court cases (e.g., <i>Brown</i> , <i>Obergefell</i> , <i>Shelby County</i>).	Arguments present but some lack case support or depth.	Weak or unsupported arguments.	Arguments missing or irrelevant.	/4
4. Opening Statement	Clear, persuasive, and concise; introduces key arguments and sets up group's stance effectively.	Clear but less compelling or slightly disorganized.	Unclear or overly long/short.	No coherent opening.	/4

Criteria	Exemplary (4 pts)	Proficient (3 pts)	Developing (2 pts)	Beginning (1 pt)	Score
5. Use of Landmark Cases	Integrates at least 2–3 relevant cases naturally into arguments (e.g., Group 2: <i>Brown v. Board</i> ; Group 3: <i>Obergefell v. Hodges</i> ; Group 4: <i>Reynolds v. Sims</i>).	Mentions cases but without deep analysis.	Cases mentioned but irrelevant or misused.	No case references.	/4
6. Responses to Follow-up Questions	Answers questions directly, thoughtfully, and with evidence; maintains respectful tone.	Answers most questions adequately but some evasion.	Struggles to answer; vague or incorrect responses.	Cannot respond meaningfully; hostile or silent.	/4
7. Group Collaboration	All members participate in research, presentation, and Q&A.	Most members participate.	Only 1–2 members contribute.	No teamwork evident.	/4
8. Connection to Modern Issues	Clearly links 14th Amendment to contemporary problems (modern immigration policies, voting rights debates, LGBTQ+ rights, etc.).	Some modern connections but underdeveloped.	Minimal or very general modern references.	No modern application.	/4

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2.3: The Constitution's 14th Amendment - Homework

Current Events Analysis Essay:

The 14th Amendment's Impact Today

This homework assignment may help you deepen your understanding of this important amendment by analyzing its application in current controversies.

Essay

Find a recent news article discussing an issue related to the 14th Amendment (e.g., immigration rights, affirmative action, equal protection challenges), then summarize the article and provide your analysis of how the amendment applies, in 400 words minimum. Be specific, and use as much of our political science terminology as you can.



Evaluation Rubric

Criteria	Excellent (4)	Proficient (3)	Developing (2)	Needs Improvement (1)
Content & Analysis	In-depth, insightful analysis of the news topic; clear understanding of context.	Solid analysis with good understanding of the topic; some depth and insight.	Basic analysis; limited depth or insight into the topic.	Superficial analysis; lacks understanding or relevance to the news topic.
Thesis Statement	Clear, concise, and compelling thesis that guides the essay effectively.	Clear thesis that is relevant and guides the essay.	Thesis is present but may be vague or not fully developed.	Thesis is unclear, missing, or irrelevant to the essay.
Evidence & Support	Strong, relevant evidence from credible sources; well-integrated and explained.	Adequate evidence from credible sources; mostly integrated and explained.	Limited evidence; may lack credibility or proper integration.	Insufficient or irrelevant evidence; sources are not credible or missing.
Structure & Organization	Logical flow with clear introduction, body, and conclusion; smooth transitions.	Clear structure with mostly logical flow and transitions.	Some organization issues; flow or transitions may be awkward.	Disorganized; lacks clear structure or logical flow.
Critical Thinking	Demonstrates exceptional critical thinking; evaluates multiple perspectives.	Shows good critical thinking; considers some alternative perspectives.	Limited critical thinking; may overlook alternative perspectives.	Lacks critical thinking; fails to consider alternative perspectives.

Criteria	Excellent (4)	Proficient (3)	Developing (2)	Needs Improvement (1)
Clarity & Style	Writing is clear, concise, and engaging; excellent grammar and word choice.	Writing is clear and mostly concise; good grammar and word choice.	Writing is somewhat unclear or wordy; occasional grammar issues.	Writing is unclear or confusing; frequent grammar or word choice errors.
Originality & Insight	Offers unique insights or original perspective on the news topic.	Provides some original thought or insight.	Limited originality; relies heavily on existing ideas.	Lacks originality; no unique insights or perspective.
Citation & References	Proper citation of all sources; accurate and consistent formatting.	Mostly proper citation; minor errors in formatting.	Some citations missing or improperly formatted.	Frequent citation errors or lack of proper references.
Relevance to News	Strong connection to current news events; timely and relevant analysis.	Good connection to current news events; relevant analysis.	Some connection to news events but may lack timeliness or relevance.	Weak or no connection to current news events.
Depth of Research	Extensive research evident; uses a variety of credible and diverse sources.	Adequate research; uses credible sources.	Limited research; relies on a narrow range of sources.	Insufficient research; lacks credible or diverse sources.

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

3: Federalism

Another foundational principle of the American political system is that of federalism, which mandates the division of political power between [federal and state governments](#).

Also called "vertical powers," the Constitution spells them out in **Article I, Section 8**, the **Tenth Amendment**, and the **Supremacy Clause**. Power sharing in its various forms allows the central and regional governments to function independently while cooperating in the governing of our nation.

The three main types of federalism we have experienced in our nation's evolution are:

1. **Dual Federalism:** A *layer cake* model where federal and state governments operate in separate spheres.
2. **Cooperative Federalism:** A *marble cake* approach with shared responsibilities.
3. **New Federalism:** A *sliced up cake*, where power is newly decentralized.

Learn more about each of these and other sub forms of federalism -and when they were prevalent in our nation- in the readings to follow.

The Effects of Federalism on DEI

Are DEI goals advanced or impeded by federalism?

Unfortunately, the answer is complex: America's decentralized government both strengthens underprivileged groups *and* upholds structural injustices.

Some states experiment with progressive policies (e.g., Illinois's cannabis legislation), while others roll back protections for minority groups (e.g., Florida's "don't say gay" law). Federal policies sometimes follow, supporting DEI or weakening it in a political landscape that is fractured and polarized.

The result is a patchwork of protections that frequently reflects profound racial, economic, and social inequalities, as well as tensions between the different federal states themselves, and with the federal government.

Nonetheless, among the recent [successes](#) in civil rights aided by federalism are:

- **Marriage Equality:** Same-sex marriage is legal in all 50 states since 2015.
- **Police Reform:** States have adopted varying use-of-force standards
- **Voting Rights:** Some states allow automatic voter registration to boost participation among marginalized groups.

Yet [setbacks](#) also occurred:

- **Restrictive Voting Laws:** Southern states' voter ID laws disproportionately disenfranchise Black and Latino voters (e.g., *Shelby County v. Holder*, 2013).
- **Anti-LGBTQ+ Policies:** Bans on gender-affirming care for minors in Texas and Florida ignore medical consensus, potentially harming transgender youth.
- **Education Censorship:** States like Tennessee banned DEI programs in public universities by, for example erasing histories of systemic racism.



Here is a summary of the Significance of Federalism:

- Policy Innovation: States serve as "laboratories of democracy"
- Checks on Power: Distributes authority to avoid tyranny.
- Representation: Enables local governance in various regions.
- Disparities in rights and services between states (such as funding for education) are a source of conflict.

Via the relevant readings, debating the pros and cons of the federal system based on case studies, and reflecting on how policies are implemented on the state and federal levels, in the readings, activities, and assignments to come, we explore in greater detail how federalism works and how it both promotes and inhibits diversity, equity, and inclusion efforts.

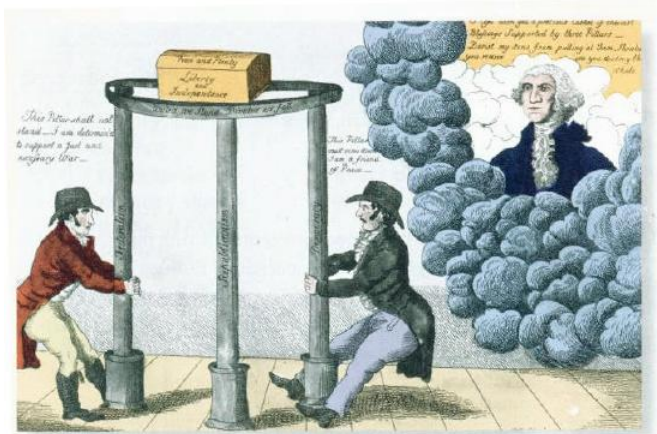
Student Learning Outcomes

1. Determine how the principles of federalism affect social, economic, and political equity.
2. Assess how federalism has shaped state authority regarding racial equity policies such as health care access and education policies.
3. Debate which government level should control equity issues between federal and state authorities.
4. Demonstrate how federalism supports or obstructs equity progress via written and oral arguments.

[3.1: Federalism - Readings and Media](#)

[3.2: Federalism - Classroom Activity](#)

[3.3: Federalism - Homework](#)



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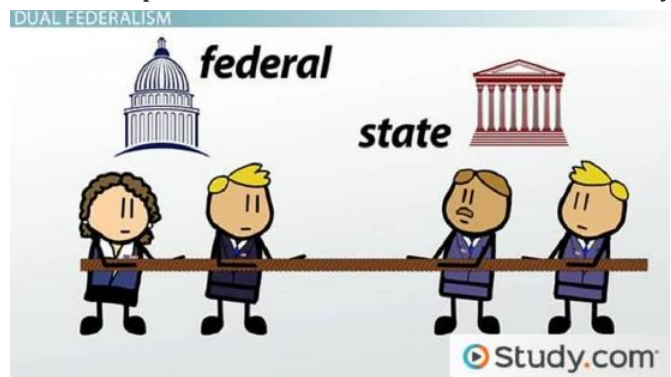
3.1: Federalism - Readings and Media

The following article and video introduces you to American federalism, its components, evolution, and relevance to our democracy and civil rights.

1. Study Hall

Study Hall, (2023, March 15). *Pros and cons of federalism | Power and politics in US government 6 of 30* [Video]. YouTube. <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=YepAnelVEJM>

With this video we further explore federalism in the United States, especially its pros and cons. How does the division of power between the federal government and state governments influence policy-making, governance, and social issues? How can we foster democratic participation and policy innovation while also overcoming challenges related to inequality, inefficiency, and legal complexity? The video provides a historical context and contemporary examples to illustrate the impact of federalism on democracy, efficiency, and individual rights as the debate over the role of federalism continues to shape U.S. politics, particularly in areas like healthcare, civil rights, and environmental policy.



2. Lumen Learning

Lumen Learning. (n.d.). *American government: The evolution of American federalism*. Retrieved from <https://courses.lumenlearning.com/atd-monroec-american-government/chapter/the-evolution-of-american-federalism/>

With this reading, go deeper into the evolution of federalism in our country, and about the different forms the relationship between the national government and the states can take. Note your thoughts on dual (1789-1930), cooperative (1930s-1960), and new federalisms (1970s-present) and pay extra attention to how federalism historically has accommodated the diversity that exists across our 50 states.

What do you think of new federalism and decentralized federalism when it comes to discussions of diversity, equity, and inclusion? Which type of federalism has produced results or is more effective?

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3.2: Federalism - Classroom Activity

Exploring Federalism in Action: A Case Study Analysis

Analyze real-world examples of federalism, evaluate its pros and cons, and propose solutions to federal-state conflicts.

1. You are **assigned to a group** and given a real-world federalism issue, for example:

- **Marijuana Legalization** – State vs. Federal drug laws
- **Voting Rights Laws** – State election rules vs. Federal oversight
- **Disaster Response** – Hurricane Katrina & FEMA's role
- **COVID-19 Policies** – State vs. Federal pandemic responses
- **Education Policy** – Common Core vs. State Curriculum

2. **Research** your topic and answer these questions:

- How does this issue illustrate federalism?
- What are the state's and federal government's roles?
- What are the benefits and drawbacks of how power is distributed?
- What solutions could improve cooperation between state and federal levels?

3. Presentation

Each group relays its case study findings.

4. Class Discussion

- Did federalism help or hurt in each case?
- How well was the public served -in all its diversity- in each case?
- Should power shift more to the states or the federal government?

Evaluation Rubric

Criteria	4 (Excellent)	3 (Good)	2 (Needs Improvement)	1 (Unsatisfactory)
Understanding of Federalism	Demonstrates a clear and thorough understanding of federalism and its principles.	Shows a good understanding of federalism with minor gaps in knowledge.	Demonstrates a basic understanding but lacks depth or accuracy.	Shows little to no understanding of federalism.
Case Study Analysis	Provides a detailed and insightful analysis of the issue, addressing all questions thoroughly.	Analyzes the issue well but may lack depth in some areas or miss minor details.	Provides a superficial analysis with limited insight or incomplete answers.	Fails to analyze the issue effectively or answer the questions adequately.
Research & Preparation	Uses a variety of reliable sources and demonstrates thorough preparation.	Uses adequate sources and shows good preparation with minor gaps.	Uses limited sources and shows minimal preparation.	Lacks research and preparation, relying on incomplete or unreliable information.



Criteria	4 (Excellent)	3 (Good)	2 (Needs Improvement)	1 (Unsatisfactory)
Presentation Skills	Presents findings clearly, confidently, and engagingly within the time limit.	Presents findings clearly and mostly confidently, with minor issues.	Presents findings with some clarity but lacks confidence or organization.	Struggles to present findings clearly or stay within the time limit.
Critical Thinking	Offers thoughtful solutions and evaluates pros/cons of federalism effectively.	Provides good solutions and evaluation but may lack depth or creativity.	Offers basic solutions and evaluation with limited critical thinking.	Fails to propose solutions or evaluate federalism effectively.
Class Discussion Participation	Actively engages in discussions, providing insightful comments and questions.	Participates in discussions with relevant contributions.	Participates minimally or with limited relevance.	Does not participate or contributes irrelevant points.

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3.3: Federalism - Homework

U.S. Federalism and Social Equity

Examine the relationship between US federalism and social equity by exploring how the distribution of power between state and federal government impacts access to rights, resources, and protections. Answer both sections below.

1. Research and Short Answer Questions

Using class materials, textbooks, and additional research, answer the following questions in **3–5 sentences each**:

- How does federalism impact social equity? Provide an example of a policy area where state and federal governments have disagreed on issues of fairness or access.
- What role did the Civil Rights Act of 1964 play in shaping federalism? How did it affect states' rights in addressing racial and economic inequality?
- How does the federal government promote equity in education, healthcare, or labor laws? Provide a specific example (e.g., Title IX, Medicaid, the Americans with Disabilities Act).
- Why do some states have stronger social safety nets than others? Discuss how federalism allows for policy differences among states and its consequences for social equity.



2. Case Study Analysis

Choose ONE of the following topics and write a **250-word analysis** on how federalism affects equity in this area:

- [Medicaid Expansion](#) – Why do some states opt out? How does this impact healthcare access?
- [Voting Rights](#) – How do state policies on voter ID laws and redistricting affect marginalized communities?
- [Environmental Justice & Federal Regulations](#) – How do state vs. federal policies impact communities of color and low-income areas?
- [Education Funding & Inequality](#) – How do disparities in state funding and federal programs affect public school quality?

In your analysis, address:

- How does this issue highlight tensions between state and federal control?
- What are the consequences for equity and fairness?
- Should the federal government intervene more or less in this area? Why?
- Do you think federalism helps or hinders social equity in the U.S.?

Evaluation Rubric

Criteria	Excellent (A)	Good (B)	Satisfactory (C)	Needs Improvement (D/F)
1. Content Accuracy & Relevance	All answers are factually accurate, fully address the prompt, and are highly relevant to federalism and equity.	Most answers are accurate and clearly address the questions; minor gaps in depth or connection.	Answers are somewhat accurate but lack detail or full relevance to the topic.	Answers are inaccurate, off-topic, or fail to address the questions.

Criteria	Excellent (A)	Good (B)	Satisfactory (C)	Needs Improvement (D/F)
2. Depth of Analysis	Demonstrates excellent critical thinking; analysis is insightful and shows clear understanding of how federalism impacts equity.	Provides thoughtful analysis with some insight; demonstrates understanding of the core themes.	Basic analysis present; ideas are underdeveloped or lack clarity.	Minimal or no analysis; answers are vague, superficial, or repetitive.
3. Use of Evidence & Examples	Effectively uses specific and appropriate examples (e.g., policies, laws, cases) to support claims.	Examples are relevant but could be more specific or better integrated.	Few examples used, or examples are too general or loosely connected.	Lacks relevant examples; little to no supporting evidence.
4. Organization & Clarity	Responses are clearly written, well-structured, and free of grammar/mechanical errors.	Mostly well-written with minor issues in clarity or structure.	Organization is inconsistent; grammar/mechanical errors occasionally interfere with meaning.	Poorly organized, unclear, and/or difficult to understand due to errors.
5. Case Study Analysis (250 words)	Provides a well-developed and focused analysis with strong connections to federalism and equity; thoroughly explains consequences.	Covers the topic with clarity; includes some analysis of federal-state dynamics and implications.	Touches on the topic but lacks depth or misses connections to core issues.	Incomplete, vague, or does not demonstrate an understanding of the topic.

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

4: Congressional Institutions

Let's now turn our attention to the institutions of the **legislative branch** of our federal government, the **US Congress**. Made up of the [House of Representatives](#) and the [Senate](#), it represents our citizenry most closely on the federal level and is therefore a cornerstone of our democracy.

Article 1 of the Constitution lays out the powers of Congress:

- [Legislate](#) - to make law
- [Power of the Purse](#) - lay and collect taxes
- [Declare War](#) - checks the president's Commander-in-Chief power
- [Oversight and Investigation](#) - can lead all the way to impeachment
- [Advice and Consent](#) - requires the president to seek confirmation from the Senate for nominations or treaties.

Learn more about each of these powers in our readings and media section to follow.

Congressional Leadership

Who has the most power in the chambers on Capitol Hill? We explore the roles of the House Speaker, the Senate Majority Leader, President Pro Tempore, and others,

Congress and DEI

Then we turn our attention on how Congress has evolved demographically over centuries, reflecting the nation's changing diversity and values, and how this has contributed to strengthening or hindering DEI realities in the nation.

Historically, the policies, and operations of Congress were dominated overwhelmingly by older white males, while women, people of color, LGBTQ+, and people with disabilities were largely excluded from access.

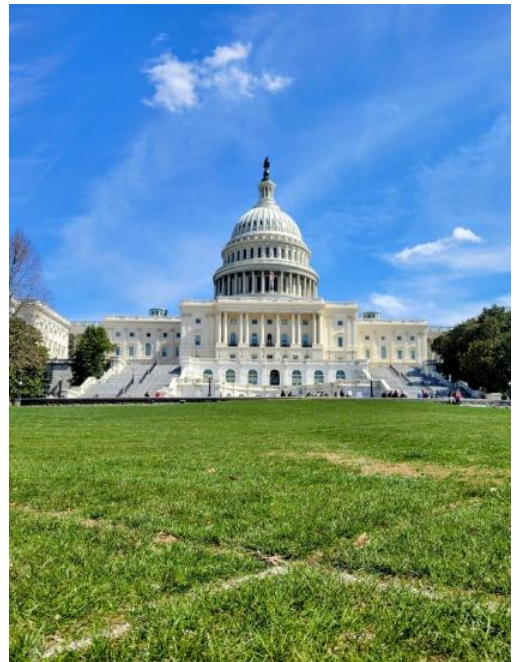
In recent years however, the trend had been toward greater [diversity, equity, and inclusion \(DEI\)](#), as voters selected ever larger numbers of diverse representatives. Although inequalities still exist, this has resulted in consecutive congresses getting increasingly diverse, with the current 119th Congress (2025–2027) being no exception.

The Congressional Research Service and the Pew Research Center state that the 119th Congress consists of:

- A record number of **women** serving in both chambers, making up about [29% of Congress](#) (149 out of 535 members). However, they still fall short of proportional representation, as women account for over 50% of the total U.S. population.
- **People of color** now hold about [28% of seats](#), including increased representation of Black (59 members), Hispanic/Latino (54 members), and Asian American/Pacific Islander (21 members) lawmakers. Though Native American representation remains low, with only a handful of members.
- **LGBTQ+**: The 119th Congress includes at least [13 openly LGBTQ+ members](#), maintaining the previous Congress's record.
- **Disability Representation**: While a few members have publicly disclosed disabilities, advocates continue pushing for greater inclusion in political leadership.

In addition to individual DEI efforts, various congressional caucuses also strive for policymaking that addresses systemic inequities, advocating for policies that promote racial and economic justice. Some example are the:

- [Congressional Black Caucus \(CBC\)](#)
- [Congressional Hispanic Caucus \(CHC\)](#), or the
- [Congressional Asian Pacific American Caucus \(CAPAC\)](#)



What do you think of the argument that the more diverse our representatives in Congress, the fairer, more just, and more inclusive our laws and society?

Answer this and other questions via the readings, activities, and assignments in the pages to follow.

[Student Learning Outcomes](#)

Explain the bicameral institutional structure of Congress, the differences between the House and the Senate, and the roles of congressional leadership.

1. Elaborate on the steps of how a bill becomes a law, and how committees and leadership in both houses direct it.
2. Evaluate how the system of checks and balances depends on Congress to perform oversight functions such as conducting impeachment proceedings and confirming executive branch appointments.
3. Assess congressional choices and their policies and social effects.
4. Practice actively engaging in civic activities including representative contact and policy advocacy, and election participation.



[4.1: Congressional Institutions - Readings and Media](#)

[4.2: Congressional Institutions - Classroom Activity](#)

[4.3: Congressional Institutions - Homework](#)

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4.1: Congressional Institutions - Readings and Media

The following readings are scaffolded to introduce you to the main components of the bicameral Congress. First, learn about the roles and responsibilities of the congressional leadership in the House and the Senate. Then evaluate the powers this leadership wields. Finally, engage in criticism of how this institution has changed over time, and in suggestions of beneficial reforms.

1. Crash Course

CrashCourse. (2015, April 17). *Congressional leadership: CrashCourse government and politics #8*. YouTube. <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=0bd55IYsaG4>

This episode engages you in some of the intricacies of hierarchy, strategy, and the influence of party leadership in Congress. While watching it, take notes on these questions:

- How does the Speaker of the House differ from the Senate Majority Leader in terms of power and responsibilities?
- Why is party leadership so important in the legislative process?
- How do whips ensure that members of Congress vote along party lines?
- In what ways can congressional leaders influence the passage (or blockage) of legislation?
- How does congressional leadership impact government gridlock and efficiency?



2. Pew Research Center

Schaeffer, K. (2023, February 7). *The changing face of Congress in 8 charts*. Pew Research Center. Retrieved from <https://www.pewresearch.org/short-reads/2023/02/07/the-changing-face-of-congress/>

Discover the demographics of our Congresses today and over time. Which trend do you notice?

3. Congress That Works

Greenblatt, J. (2018, November 6). *Diversity in Congress: By the numbers + why it matters*. Congress That Works. Retrieved from <https://congressthatworks.com/diversity-in-congress-by-the-numbers-why-it-matters/>

Get another perspective on how representation in the U.S. legislature has evolved, and why it matters for democracy. How do the growing numbers of women, racial and ethnic minorities, and younger lawmakers, affect policymaking, public trust, and political participation? Think about the relationship between descriptive representation and social equity, and critically assess how the composition of Congress influences debates on civil rights, economic justice, and inclusion.

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4.2: Congressional Institutions - Classroom Activity

Leadership Strategy Session

Role-play congressional leaders and rank-and-file members to simulate how parties strategize to pass or block major legislation.

Preparation

You are assigned to one of the two main political parties (e.g., Democrat or Republican) and you are given a leadership role:

- [Speaker of the House](#)
- [House Majority or Minority Leader](#)
- [Senate Majority or Minority Leader](#)
- [Party Whips](#) (House or Senate)
- [Rank-and-file Members](#), organized into caucuses.



Explore the Legislative Scenario

- Democrats want to expand government-funded healthcare such as medicare.
- Republicans oppose the expansion of medicare and prefer a free-market approach.
- The bill is being debated in both chambers, and party leaders must strategize their next steps.

Instructions

1. [Party Strategy Meeting](#)

- Majority and minority party leaders meet with their caucuses to discuss their approach.
- Whips count votes and assess party loyalty.
- Leaders discuss potential concessions or compromise

2. [Negotiations](#)

- Party leaders meet with each other to see if a bipartisan agreement is possible.
- Individual members can lobby for amendments or changes to the bill
- The House or Senate vote

3. [Debrief](#)

- What strategies worked, where there were challenges, and how?
- Which political actors influenced the outcome the most?
- How does party leadership influence legislative success or failure?
- What role do party whips play in ensuring unity?
- How do party leaders handle intra-party disagreements?
- Which groups of our society were impacted by your decisions, and how?

Evaluation Rubric

Participation in Leadership Simulation (Role-Play & Strategy Session) – 25%

Criteria	Excellent (10)	Proficient (8)	Developing (6)	Needs Improvement (4)

Criteria	Excellent (10)	Proficient (8)	Developing (6)	Needs Improvement (4)
Engagement	Actively participates, demonstrates strong leadership, and stays in character throughout.	Participates and stays in character but lacks strong leadership or engagement.	Occasionally participates but is inconsistent in role-play.	Minimal participation and little effort in staying in character.
Strategic Thinking	Uses well-developed strategies, considers multiple perspectives, and adapts effectively.	Demonstrates strategic thinking but may miss key considerations.	Some strategic elements are present, but reasoning lacks depth.	Limited or no strategic approach.
Collaboration & Negotiation	Works effectively with peers, engages in meaningful negotiation.	Engages in negotiation but may struggle with collaboration.	Basic effort to collaborate, but lacks depth.	Does not engage with peers effectively.

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